

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **The IEA said member countries** would release a record 400 million barrels of oil from their emergency stocks in a bid to bring down crude prices that have soared during the war with Iran. **A1**
- ◆ **The Dow fell 0.6%** to its lowest close of the year, hurt by higher oil prices, while the S&P 500 slipped 0.1% and the Nasdaq rose 0.1%. **B1**
- ◆ **Annual inflation held steady** last month as consumer prices rose 2.4% from a year earlier and were even with the increase in January. **A1**
- ◆ **Billionaire Tilman Fertitta** has been in exclusive talks to buy Caesars Entertainment for roughly \$7 billion after he topped a competing offer from Carl Icahn's firm. **B1**
- ◆ **Papa John's International** is reviewing a bid from a Qatari-backed investment fund to take the pizza chain private at a valuation of about \$1.5 billion. **B1**
- ◆ **McDonald's plans** to launch new deals and discounts to keep the fast-food chain ahead of competitors in the battle for consumers' dollars. **B1**
- ◆ **Activists who encouraged** shoppers to boycott Target over its retreat from DEI acknowledged a breakdown in trust with the Black community and that their official work on the boycott will end. **B3**
- ◆ **Cintas agreed** to acquire UniFirst in a deal with an enterprise value of \$5.5 billion more than four years after it first bid for the smaller uniform supplier. **B3**
- ◆ **BlackRock is committing** \$100 million of grant capital to fund and expand training programs in the skilled trades. **B2**

Worldwide

- ◆ **Escalating Iranian attacks** and the U.S. government's decision to hold off on military escorts for oil tankers through the Strait of Hormuz are raising the prospect of a prolonged closure that would choke off exports through the world's most important energy-transport route. **A1, A6**
- ◆ **Returning to Russian fossil fuels** in the wake of the Iran war would be a "strategic blunder," the president of the European Commission said. **A6**
- ◆ **The Justice Department** is investigating Iran's use of Binnacle to evade U.S. sanctions, focusing on money flowing through the platform to a network funding terror groups. **A1**
- ◆ **Trump ordered the Justice Department** to reinstate sanctions on law firms he had singled out after the department said it wouldn't defend the president's directives. **A3**
- ◆ **Ireland's prime minister** plans to talk about investing billions in the U.S. as part of an annual St. Patrick's Day visit to the White House on March 17. **A3**
- ◆ **The Trump administration** announced new tariff investigations targeting excess industrial capacity and forced labor regulations that could result in higher levies on scores of nations. **A2**
- ◆ **Republican Sen. John Cornyn** reversed himself to say that he would now support changes to the Senate filibuster rule that requires 60 votes to advance most legislation. **A3**
- ◆ **José Antonio Kast** was sworn in as Chile's new president, marking the nation's most pronounced shift to the right since the return of democracy in 1990. **A9**

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ROYAL THAI NAVY/AGENCE FRANCE PRESSE/GETTY IMAGES

A Thai cargo ship hit by a projectile burns Wednesday off Oman in the Strait of Hormuz in a picture provided by the Thai navy. Iran has effectively stopped cargo traffic through the strait.

Tehran Steps Up Ship Attacks As Strait Closure Reverberates

Escalating Iranian attacks and the U.S. government's decision to hold off on military escorts for oil tankers through the Strait of Hormuz are rais-

By Jared Malsin,
Summer Said
and Shelby Holliday

ing the prospect of a prolonged closure that would choke off exports through the world's most important energy-transport route.

On Wednesday, the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps struck three cargo ships attempting to transit the waterway, the only sea route out of the Persian Gulf. Two foreign tankers carrying fuel oil in Iraqi waters were later set ablaze by projectiles. One crew member was killed and 37 were rescued, an Iraqi official said. The U.S. has turned down repeated requests for tanker escorts from oil companies, officials from Gulf countries

said. Defense officials said it is too risky to send warships into the confined waters of the strait—which is around 21 miles wide at its narrowest point—until the risks of Iranian fire have receded. U.S. forces have hit Iran's navy and its drone and missile crews, in an effort to curb the threat. But Iran is still landing blows. Added to that are the risks of naval mines and Iranian submarines.

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Inflation Steadies, but War Poses Threat

By JUSTIN LAHART

Annual inflation held steady last month, but the outlook for prices has become cloudy as the U.S.-Israeli war with Iran poses a threat to economies across the globe. Consumer prices rose 2.4% in February from a year earlier, the Labor Department reported Wednesday. That compared with 2.4% in January

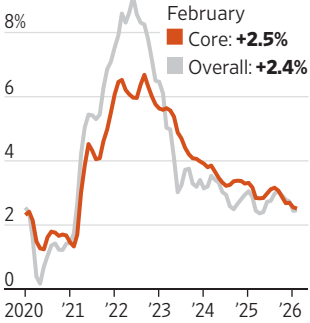
and was even with what economists surveyed by The Wall Street Journal had expected. Core prices, which exclude volatile food and energy items, rose 2.5% from a year earlier, also in line with expectations. Before the launch of the U.S.-Israeli war with Iran on Feb. 28, Wednesday's inflation report would have been a key reading, shaping expectations for Federal Reserve policy in

the months ahead. Now it is something more like a baseline—the reading against which economists will measure whatever the war does to prices in the months ahead. “The February data is already completely inconsequential,” said Joseph Brusuelas, chief economist at RSM. The Dow Jones Industrial Average, pressured by a new

climb in oil prices, fell 289 points, or 0.6%, to 47417 Wednesday, its lowest closing price since Dec. 1. The S&P 500 and the Nasdaq composite both fell 0.1%. The report is unlikely to alter the wait-and-see posture Fed officials have taken so far this year. Core prices rose just 0.22% from a month earlier, a relative

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Consumer-price index, change from a year earlier



Note: Data for October 2025 is unavailable. Core excludes food and energy prices. Source: Labor Department

Economy	Shipping	Strategy	Markets	Heard on the Street
Wild swings in fuel prices leave no nation untouched. A6	U.S. plan to insure Hormuz ships hits snags. A6	Ending war quickly poses risks for U.S., allies. A8	Blue chips fall to new low for the year. B1	Renewables get a lift in Europe. B11

Too Big to Spell? Global Elite Give Up on Grammar

The rich and powerful share a seeming disregard for proper English; Hello, 'Daivd'

By RACHEL LOUISE ENSIGN
AND ALEXANDRA WEXLER

Is it laziness, illiteracy or the ultimate flex? Missives from titans of business and politics show a striking disregard for spelling, punctuation and proper grammar.

Jack Dorsey's memo last month laying off nearly half of Block's staff was almost entirely in lowercase. Paramount Skydance Chief David Ellison addressed Warner Bros.

Discovery's David Zaslav as "Daivd" over text last year while trying to strike a deal. The famous hack at Sony Pictures revealed executives sending messages like "WE ALL HAVE TO SIT DOWNTTT TALK ABOUT TH NEXT DRAYFT."

Then there are the Epstein files, which are riddled with

egregious misspellings and lackluster punctuation by not just convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein, a college dropout, but also his Ivy League connections and wealthy friends.

The literary breaches, while trivial, highlight a reality that has become all too clear: There's an inverse correlation between power and proper punctuation.

Before the digital era, executives, lawmakers and other important people often communicated via secretaries and press releases. Now they fire off messages from their phones and computers day and night. Voice-to-text and autocorrect functions can make things worse.

Disregarding spelling and grammar in a written conversation can be a power move or

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INSIDE



ISTOCK

PERSONAL JOURNAL
The financial scams targeting older adults—and how to fight them. **A10**



SPORTS
Bam Adebayo's 83-point outburst just rewrote the NBA record books. **A16**

Autism Therapy Is Fastest-Growing Jackpot in Medicaid

Companies have found opportunities to capitalize on a growing need

When Meghann Mitchell first launched her autism-therapy business in 2019, she took aim at an unlikely source of profit: Indiana's taxpayer-funded Medicaid program, the public insurance system for the poor.

By Christopher Weaver,
Tom McGinty and
Anna Wilde Mathews

The bet paid off. In 2023, the state paid Mitchell's company, Piece by Piece Autism Centers, \$29 million to provide therapy to just 84 patients—about \$340,000 a child—according to a Wall Street Journal analysis of Medicaid billing records.

That amount surpassed what Indiana Medicaid typi-

cally spends in a year treating a newly diagnosed lung-cancer patient or covering a year of nursing-home care.

Piece by Piece became one of Medicaid's most expensive providers in part by raising its prices, triggering reimbursements as high as \$640 an hour for routine therapy that can be administered by workers with little more than a high-school diploma. Its highest payments were more than 10 times higher than the nation's average.

Mitchell said her company complied with Indiana's rules and the state never objected to her prices.

"I don't think Indiana really had any oversight, or not much," said Mitchell, who

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